

Religious Conversion and Women's Economic Emancipation:

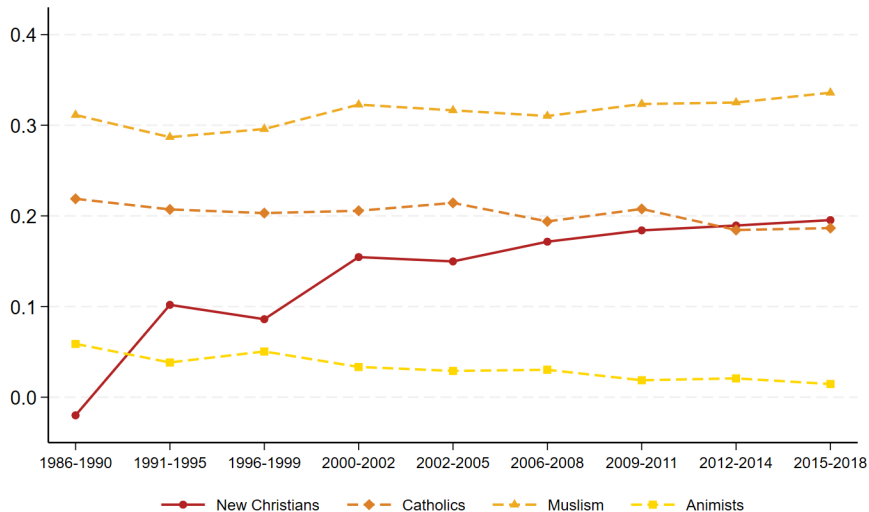
Descriptive and Causal Evidence from Sub-Saharan Africa

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The "New Reformation" in SSA



Source: Data comes 115 Demographic and Health Surveys in 39 countries (N=1,882,230).

Motivation

- SSA is undergoing since a few decades a new **massive conversion movement**
- Yet, its causes and consequences are still far from being well understood
[Ager and Ciccone (2017), Auriol et al. (2020), Chen (2010), Hersey (2024), and Sinding Bentzen (2019)]

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[Ager and Ciccone (2017), Auriol et al. (2020), Chen (2010), Hersey (2024), and Sinding Bentzen (2019)]
- This societal transformation will likely trigger profound changes:
 - New post-colonial Christian churches oppose traditional beliefs and some elements of the social system that they consider unacceptable
 - The departure from traditional norms, beliefs, and rituals may have major consequences for economic growth and development
[Henrich (2020), Jonathan F Schulz (2022), and Jonathan F. Schulz et al. (2019, 2023)]

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- What are the **causes and consequences of the shift towards new Christian churches** in Sub-Saharan Africa?
- We argue that this conversion movement is partly **promoted by women** who see in religious conversion a privileged way of **emancipating themselves from the traditional social order**

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 4. Women use religious conversion strategically to gain economic independence

Context

Religious conversion as an emancipation strategy

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- Traditional religious beliefs and the associated clan-based norms are highly patriarchal, support high fertility and impose high taxes on economic activities

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[Kennedy (1988), Platteau (2014), and Sarro (2009)]
- Importantly (and in contrast to other alternatives), religious conversion avoids harmful hostility from the upholders of the tradition
 - The new set of obligations and behaviours are now judged to be religiously determined rather than the result of selfish individualism

Religious conversion and *women's* emancipation

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 - "African" churches have rules and prohibitions that benefit women (e.g., bans on alcohol and polygamy)

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 - Churches may act as "safe spaces" for women: they have women-only associations that amplify social networks and increase bargaining power
 - Provision of goods and services that would not be accessible otherwise: access to contraceptives, insurance, help to find a job, or clothes and food

Data

Data

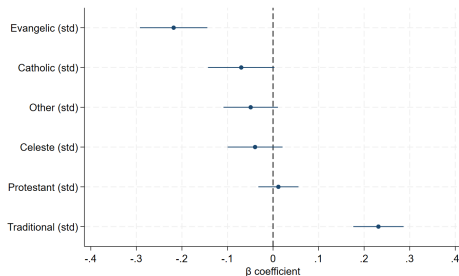
- We rely on two main data sources:
 - Large-scale demographic surveys across Sub-Saharan Africa:
 - DHS: 115 Surveys in 39 countries (n=1.86 million)
 - Afrobarometer: 220 Surveys in 39 countries (n=316.000)
 - PEW: 19 countries (n=25.000)
 - World Value Surveys: 26 surveys in 12 countries (n=45.000)
 - First-hand data from a randomized controlled trial in rural Benin (n=1800)
 - In kind subsidy + business training for women to start/expand an agricultural production
 - Two business training: women alone or husband invited

Part 1: Empirical Regularities

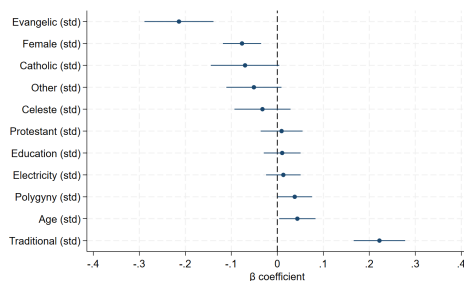
1.1. New Christian religions and traditional beliefs

New Christian religions and traditional beliefs

Figure 1: Correlation between belief in ancestral spirits and religion



a) Religion fixed effects



b) Religion fixed effects and sociodemographic controls

Notes: The figure shows the plotted coefficients of regressing a dummy variable that equals one if the respondent believes that the spirits of his/her ancestors have an influence on his/her life on religion fixed effects (Panel a) or on religion fixed effects and a set of control variables (panel b).

- New (endogenous) Christian churches strongly oppose traditional beliefs

Part 1: Empirical Regularities

1.2. The gender composition of religions

The Gender Composition of Religions

	DHS		Afrobarometer		PEW		WVS		South Benin		North Benin	
	Trad. (1)	Christian (2)	Trad. (3)	Christian (4)	Trad. (5)	Christian (6)	Trad. (7)	Christian (8)	Trad. (9)	Christian (10)	Trad. (11)	Christian (12)
Female/100	-0.706*** (0.0331)	2.198*** (0.0613)	-0.702*** (0.0439)	2.788*** (0.138)	-0.932*** (0.165)	6.435*** (0.569)	0.0170 (0.0801)	2.882*** (0.656)	-7.295*** (1.798)	5.577** (2.660)	-22.26*** (5.875)	20.83*** (5.726)
Controls	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Country FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	No	No	No	No
Mean Y	0.0217	0.168	0.0152	0.194	0.0172	0.370	0.00550	0.193	0.103	0.315	0.509	0.395
N	1637038	1637038	303659	303659	24015	24015	30747	30747	1703	1703	344	344

NOTE. Data: DHS, Afrobarometer, PEW, WVS, first-hand data from southern and northern Benin. The outcome variable is an indicator that equals one if the respondent's religion is Traditional (columns 1,3,5,7,9,11), or "New" Christian (columns 2,4,6,8,10,12). In column 12, we do not have information on the type of Christian religion. Controls include age, education, whether the respondent did not have money at some point during the last year to buy food for his/her family (PEW only), whether the respondent is married (except Afrobarometer), whether the respondent has a formal employment (except PEW), the respondent's self-reported economic situation (Afrobarometer only), the respondent's position in the income distribution (WVS only), whether the respondent lives in a rural area (except WVS), access to electricity ((first-hand data from Benin)), agricultural production (first-hand data from Benin), and assets score (first-hand data from Benin).

- Women are **less** likely to be members of Traditional religions
- Women are **more** likely to be members of new Christian churches

The Gender Composition of Religions

	Traditional beliefs				
	Vodoun (1)	Ancestors (2)	Sodabi (3)	Bokono/Fetish (4)	Evangelic (5)
Female/100	-7.295*** (1.798)	-14.69*** (2.735)	-5.392** (2.339)	-9.690*** (2.271)	5.577** (2.660)
Controls	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Mean Y	0.103	0.367	0.146	0.156	0.315
N	1703	1705	1383	1480	1703

NOTE. Data: First-hand data collected in southern Benin. The outcome variable is an indicator that equals one if the respondent's religion is Vodoun (column 1), Evangelism (column 2), if the respondent believes that the spirits of his/her ancestors influence his/her life (column 3), if the respondent has consulted a "bokono" (sorcerer) or has used a fetish to prevent coronavirus (column 4), or if the respondent has drunk sodabi (traditional alcoholic drink) to prevent coronavirus (column 5). Individual controls include age, education, marital status, pineapple producer, and electricity at home in 2020.

- Women are **less** likely to hold traditional beliefs

Part 1: Empirical Regularities

1.3. New Christian churches and socioeconomic outcomes

Labor market outcomes and reproductive decisions

	Employed (1)	Self-employed (2)	Contraceptives (3)	Ideal children (4)	Number children (5)
New Christian	0.00712*** (0.00232)	-0.0425*** (0.00229)	0.0471*** (0.00260)	-3.833*** (0.123)	-0.396*** (0.0127)
Female	-0.175*** (0.00141)	-0.0521*** (0.00144)	-0.0754*** (0.00113)	-0.0489 (0.0660)	0.602*** (0.00454)
New Christian x Female	0.0246*** (0.00277)	0.0362*** (0.00246)	0.00753*** (0.00252)	1.439*** (0.113)	0.0471*** (0.0101)
Country-round FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Controls	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Mean Y	0.703	0.260	0.235	11.75	2.858
R-squared	0.202	0.198	0.111	0.106	0.569
N	1639972	1633955	1658667	1695818	1742828

NOTE. Data: DHS. "New Christian" is a dummy that equals one if the respondent reports one of the new Christian religions as their main religion. Outcome variables are: probability of working (column 1), probability of working as a self-employed in agriculture (column 2), use of contraceptives at the time of the survey (column 3), ideal number of children (column 4), and total number of children ever born (column 5). Country-round FE and individual controls included: age and age squared. Standard errors clustered at the DHS cluster level.

- Members of new Christian churches have **better labor market and reproductive outcomes**

Goods and services provision

	Church provides:			
	Food/Clothing (1)	Help job (2)	Help house (3)	Language/Literacy (4)
New Christian	0.0752*** (0.00895)	0.0762*** (0.00915)	0.0477*** (0.00903)	-0.0120 (0.00916)
Female	0.00218 (0.00909)	-0.00297 (0.00868)	-0.00322 (0.00867)	-0.00767 (0.00898)
New Christian x Female	0.0116 (0.0123)	-0.00656 (0.0124)	-0.000336 (0.0123)	0.000847 (0.0126)
Controls	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Country FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Mean Y	0.630	0.400	0.377	0.538
N	23283	23271	23258	23259

NOTE. Data: PEW. The outcome variable is an indicator that equals one if the church the respondent most often attends provides: i) food or clothing (column 1); ii) help with finding a job (column 2); iii) help finding house (column 3); and iv) language or literacy training (column 4). Country fixed-effects always included. Controls include age and age squared.

- New Christian churches provide **more goods and services**

Women empowerment

	Who makes decisions regarding:				
	Earnings (1)	Health (2)	Purchases (3)	Visits (4)	Index (5)
New Christian	-0.0624*** (0.00491)	0.120*** (0.00385)	0.122*** (0.00359)	0.113*** (0.00381)	0.101*** (0.00310)
Country-round FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Controls	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Mean Y	2.486	1.711	1.624	1.797	1.841
R-squared	0.133	0.164	0.147	0.100	0.252
N	382887	715299	718185	718148	768747

NOTE. Data: DHS. The sample is restricted to women. "New Christian" is a dummy that equals one if the respondent reports one of the new Christian religions as their main religion. Outcome variables: Who makes decisions regarding... [1-3]: Women are asked who usually decides on (1) how a woman's earning are used, (2) healthcare, (3) large household purchases, (4) visiting family. I rescale the response options so that it is a 1 to 3 categorical variable where 1 is Partner/Other Person decides, 2 is Respondent and Partner together decide, and 3 is Respondent alone decides. Country-round FE and individual controls included: age and age squared. Standard errors clustered at the DHS cluster level.

- Women from new Christian religions have **greater autonomy in decision-making**

Women empowerment

	Beating justified if:					
	Goes out (1)	Neglects children (2)	Argues (3)	Refuses sex (4)	Burns food (5)	Index (6)
New Christian	-0.0539*** (0.00236)	-0.0391*** (0.00233)	-0.0469*** (0.00231)	-0.0698*** (0.00229)	-0.0453*** (0.00205)	-0.0503*** (0.00202)
Country-round FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
DHS Cluster FE						
Controls	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Mean Y	0.344	0.374	0.313	0.272	0.188	0.300
R-squared	0.130	0.112	0.127	0.137	0.0921	0.162
N	1028921	1030270	1009776	1015756	1011907	1037150

NOTE. Data: DHS. The sample is restricted to women. "New Christian" is a dummy that equals one if the respondent reports one of the new Christian religions as their main religion. Outcome variables are dummy variables that equal one if the respondent says that domestic violence is justify in different scenarios. The index is the average of all non-missing responses to these Yes or No questions. Country-round FE and individual controls included: age and age squared. Standard errors clustered at the DHS cluster level.

- Women from new Christian religions have **lower tolerance of domestic violence**

Part 2: Causal Evidence

Exogenous economic shock and religious conversion

Randomized Experiment

- We conducted a RCT in southern Benin (N=1009) that generated exogenous variation in (future) income:
 - Women were assigned to two treatment arms:
 - In-kind subsidy + business training **alone**
 - In-kind subsidy + business training **together with their husband**
 - Does this positive economic shock trigger conversion?
 - If it's a matter of emancipating from the influence of family/clan, is husband's support important?

Business training: alone vs in couples

	Husband too involved	Knows spouse's income	
	(1)	Women (2)	Men (3)
Individual (T) vs Couple (C)	0.166*** (0.0433)		
Individual		0.0213 (0.0714)	0.0686 (0.0734)
Couple		0.153** (0.0694)	0.150** (0.0716)
Mean Y	0.598	1.967	2.504
N	500	872	843

NOTE. Data: First-hand data collected in southern Benin. "Individual" =1 if the household has been assigned to the treatment group where women attended the business training alone. "Couple"=1 if the household has been assigned to the treatment group where women attended the business training with their husband. Robust standard errors in parenthesis.

- The business training together **fosters cooperation**

Exogenous economic shock and religious conversion

	Religious conversion since baseline (2020)			
	Women		Men	
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
Treated	0.0396* (0.0234)		-0.0285 (0.0258)	
Individual		0.0568** (0.0281)		-0.0270 (0.0294)
Couple		0.0220 (0.0269)		-0.0300 (0.0291)
Mean Y	0.144	0.144	0.130	0.130
N	942	942	831	831

NOTE. Data: "Treated" =1 if the hh was assigned to the treatment group. "Individual" =1 if the household has been assigned to the business training alone. "Couple" =1 if the household has been assigned to the business training with husbands.

- A positive income shock **increases conversion... but only if the husband was not included**

Conclusion

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- The massive conversion movement to new (endogenous) Christian churches is far from well understood
- We argue that it may be partly driven by women who see religious conversion as a way to emancipate from the restrictions of tradition
- We have shown that:
 1. New Christian churches oppose traditional beliefs and practices
 2. Women are more likely to be members of new Christian churches (and less likely to be members of Traditional religions)
 3. New Christian religions are positively associated to labor market outcomes, reproductive choices, and goods/services provision
 4. Women may use conversion strategically to gain economic independence

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Results: New Christian religions and traditional beliefs

	Rituals		Sacrifices		Witchcraft		Initiation		Miracle	
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)	(7)	(8)	(9)	(10)
New Christian	-0.0434*** (0.00623)	-0.0519*** (0.00860)	-0.0811*** (0.00656)	-0.0802*** (0.00909)	-0.0455*** (0.00676)	-0.0743*** (0.00899)	-0.0496*** (0.00630)	-0.0356*** (0.00867)	0.203*** (0.00717)	0.170*** (0.00959)
Muslim		-0.0636*** (0.00980)		-0.0422*** (0.0104)		-0.0780*** (0.0102)		-0.0193* (0.00996)		-0.0675*** (0.0110)
Traditional		0.550*** (0.0169)		0.496*** (0.0173)		0.298*** (0.0228)		0.521*** (0.0194)		0.0970*** (0.0263)
Controls	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Country FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Mean Y	0.262	0.262	0.328	0.328	0.456	0.456	0.267	0.267	0.476	0.476
N	23414	23414	22697	22697	22730	22730	23355	23355	23554	23554

NOTE. Data: PEW Research Center. The table reports OLS estimates. The outcome variable is: dummy=1 if the respondent has ever participated in an African traditional ceremony or performed rituals to honor ancestors (columns 1 and 2), dummy=1 if the respondent believes that sacrifices to ancestors prevents from bad things happening (columns 3 and 4), dummy=1 if the respondent believes in witchcraft (columns 5 and 6), dummy=1 if the respondent has ever participated in an initiation ritual (columns 7 and 8), dummy=1 if the respondent has experienced a divine miracle (columns 9 and 10). Individual controls include age, urban/rural place of residence, marital status, education, and whether the respondent has recently experienced a money shortage.